text messages and calls and made plenty myself. Despite trying my best to speak to every person who played a key role in my life, I missed out on calling many. I am sure they will all understand how much I value their contribution and that the omission was totally unintentional.

I continued sending messages late into the night, but that is not to suggest I was having trouble sleeping again. On the contrary, I slept very well and was very much at peace with myself. On the other hand, I was still an active cricketer. I wasn't prepared to lead a retired cricketer's life just yet and I was looking forward to resuming practice the next day and doing my best for Mumbai and India in the month I had left.

Getting ready for the West Indies

My practice sessions following the announcement were very interesting. The next morning I went to the Mumbai Cricket Association's Bandra facility to practise and the groundsmen came over to see me. They all thanked me for my contribution to cricket, when it should have been me thanking them for all they had done for me. Some became quite emotional and said they would miss me now that I wouldn't be turning up to practise any more. I reminded them that I hadn't retired quite yet, and in any case I would still come and practise after I'd retired – there was no way I was going to leave them in peace!

The evening before my last session at the MCA, I called the supervisor Ajay Desai and asked him to inform all the groundsmen and helpers that I would like to meet them personally the next morning. It was my way of recognizing everything they had done for me and thanking them for their contribution to my career. I carried tokens of appreciation for them and it was deeply touching to see them all waiting patiently for me. As I thanked them for their help and support, some hugged me and a few had tears in their eyes. It was a very moving moment and I felt humbled. The best part, however, was yet to come. When I'd finished, I was expecting the groundsmen to resume their normal duties. However, to my surprise they announced that on this occasion they weren't going to leave me. Instead, they all stood there while I went through my routine. Having spent a lifetime with the groundsmen in Mumbai, I must say I was overwhelmed at the gesture.

It was a similar story with the groundsmen at the Wankhede. I have known these men for years and many watched me grow up as a cricketer.